

EPILOGUE: WASTE NOT

This year marks the one hundredth anniversary of Frederick Winslow Taylor's *The Principles of Scientific Management*, first published in 1911. The movement for scientific management changed the course of the twentieth century by making possible the tremendous prosperity that we take for granted today. Taylor effectively invented what we now consider simply management: improving the efficiency of individual workers, management by exception (focusing only on unexpectedly good or bad results), standardizing work into tasks, the task-plus-bonus system of compensation, and—above all—the idea that work can be studied and improved through conscious effort. Taylor invented modern white-collar work that sees companies as systems that must be managed at more than the level of the individual. There is a reason all past management revolutions have been led by engineers: management is human systems engineering.

In 1911 Taylor wrote: “In the past, the man has been first; in the future, the system must be first.” Taylor’s prediction has come to pass. We are living in the world he imagined. And yet, the revolution that he unleashed has been—in many ways—too successful. Whereas Taylor preached science as a way of thinking, many people confused his message with the rigid techniques he advocated: time and motion studies, the differential piece-rate system, and—most galling of all—the idea that workers should be treated as little more than automatons. Many of these ideas proved extremely harmful and required the efforts of later theorists and